

per cent in 2024-25—a 14-year high and nearly double the national average—as evidence that welfare expansion has not come at the cost of economic performance. Sources say particular attention is being paid to funnel welfare into segments where victory margins were narrow in 2021.

One Battle After Another

At the same time, the DMK has framed this election as part of a broader contest over Centre-state relations. Here, the Dravidian party positions itself as a defender of Tamil Nadu's autonomy within India's federal framework.

Federalism remains a key pillar of Stalin's political messaging. The DMK has reiterated demands for greater fiscal devolution, including an increased share of Goods and Services Tax (GST) revenues for states. It has also opposed proposals such as 'One Nation, One Election', the NEP (National Education Policy) and called for the removal of centralised entrance tests such as NEET in higher education. In fact, the party continues to advocate for moving education back to the state list and maintains its long-standing opposition to the imposition of Hindi.

While these positions are not new, their renewed emphasis serves a strategic purpose. By framing the election as one between "Tamil Nadu and Delhi", the DMK seeks to consolidate regional identity while countering the expansion efforts of the BJP in the state. In fact, Stalin's son and deputy CM Udhayanidhi Stalin has gone so far as to call the election "a contest between our CM and Prime Minister Narendra Modi".

The principal challenger is its old rival, the AIADMK. Under former CM Edappadi K. Palaniswami (EPS), it has had frosty ties with the BJP. After tactically opting to return to the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) umbrella a year ago, it has laboured to retain the sense of being its dominant constituent. It has not been immune to coalition woes either. The late Vijayakant's Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK) has moved to the DMK fold as has the rebellious ex-CM, O. Panneerselvam (OPS). V.K. Sasikala, the former all-powerful aide of late CM J. Jayalalithaa, has launched her own politi-



BATTLE STATIONS
AIADMK chief EPS with Mylapore candidate and BJP leader Tamilisai Soundararajan; right, TVK chief Vijay at a rally in Kolathur, Chennai, Mar. 30

THE CHALLENGER

Edappadi K. Palaniswami, 71, AIADMK
Party general secretary, former Tamil Nadu CM

KEY STRATEGIES

- AIADMK has been rebuilding its organisational network, focusing on traditional strongholds, particularly in the Kongu region of western TN
- The alliance, including the BJP, AMMK and the Anbumani Ramadoss faction of PMK, had a headstart in campaigning after sealing seat talks early
- Internal fragmentation an issue. O. Panneerselvam and DMDK have moved to the DMK side; V.K. Sasikala and S. Ramadoss faction of PMK bent on muddying the waters for AIADMK
- The party has sharpened its attacks on the DMK, focusing on anti-incumbency narratives such as deteriorating law and order, safety of women, rising prices and charges of administrative inefficiency
- BJP focus is on strengthening cadre base, expanding digital outreach, mobilising sections of OBC communities

Pre-election routines remain the same in Tamil Nadu. Both AIADMK and DMK have tried to outbid the other in freebie promises, starting from fridges to cash doles and much more